

Drop the scope, not the price

When a client's budget is lower than your quote, hold the rate and take scope out. A discount teaches the client the first number was padding, and they'll open lower next time. A scope change teaches them the price is real. Keep the planning and the filming, because that's where the quality lives, and reduce the deliverables, the revision rounds or the timing instead. Then say it as a trade, not a concession: "I can work with that budget. Here's what changes."

Why does a discount cost more than the margin on one job?

A discount costs you the margin on this job and the price on every job that follows, because it teaches the client that your number was never real.

When a client says "that's more than we have", the reflex is to knock something off. It feels like the helpful move, the relationship-saving move. It's neither. Every time you drop your price to land a job, you teach the client three things. The first number wasn't real. Your rate is soft. And there's always a lower one if they push.

That lesson doesn't stay on this job. It shows up on the next quote and the one after, because now they know to open low. You didn't save the relationship. You trained your own buyer to negotiate you down.

There's a second cost, closer to home. A discount means doing the same work for less, so the only things that give are your margin and your goodwill, and you end up resenting a job you fought to win.

The pattern is sharpest in a quiet month. "Work has been incredibly quiet. I really need the money." I've heard that sentence from an owner while he was cutting a \$7,000 job to \$4,700. The discount taught that client the first number was padding, and to ask again next time. The quiet month is the worst time to set your prices, and it's exactly when most owners do.

How to meet a lower budget without discounting: the method, step by step

The method is to hold the rate, decide what stays, take scope out, and say it as a trade. Six steps, and the first one takes thirty seconds.

1. **Get the real budget number, including whether it includes tax.** Ask: "What's the budget you're working to, and is that including GST?" The worked example below turns on exactly that gap. You leave that conversation with one number, tax position clear, written down.
2. **Decide what stays.** Planning and filming stay as quoted. That's where the quality lives, and a film shot in a hurry with no prep becomes the client's idea of your standard. Write that short list down before you touch anything else.
3. **Decide what comes out, in this order.** Deliverables first (the third social cut, the extra version, the behind-the-scenes piece). Then revision rounds (one included round instead of two, further rounds priced). Then timing (the hero film now, the cuts as a second job later). Each line comes out at the rate it went in at, so the number drops because the work drops. Done looks like: a revised scope that adds up to the budget without a single rate changing.
4. **Say it as a trade, not a concession.** No apology, no "I can probably do something on the price". The wording is below, and the sentence that matters is the one about planning and filming staying the same, because it tells the client what the reduction is protecting. The test is simple: no apology in it, and it ends on a question.
5. **Send the revised scope in writing, with the inclusions and exclusions spelt out.** How many revision rounds are in, what's delivered, and what triggers a variation: a new location, new interviewees, a change of brief after the script is approved, or a further round of changes. Nothing on that list should surprise anyone at invoice time. Done looks like: a one-page revised quote, same rate, fewer lines, one clear next step to accept.
6. **If they push again, hold.** If the client wants the full scope at the lower number, the answer is a kind no. Put the three options below in front of them and let them choose. Whichever option they pick, the price hasn't moved.

Copy and paste: the scope script

"I can work with that budget. Here's what changes: instead of [three 30-second cuts], we deliver [two]. Planning and filming stay as quoted, because that's where the quality lives. Want me to send the revised scope?"

It frames the reduction as a deliberate trade, protects the quality, keeps the rate whole, and hands the client a clean choice: this budget buys this much.

Copy and paste: the three-option scope-down

Option 1, full scope as quoted: [everything in the original quote]. \$[quoted price].

Option 2, reduced scope at your budget: [what stays, for example planning, filming, the hero film and two social cuts]. [What comes out, for example the third social cut and one revision round]. \$[budget].

Option 3, phased delivery: [planning and the hero film] now at \$[phase one]; [the social cuts] as a second job in [month] at \$[phase two].

All three are built at the same rate. The difference is what's delivered and when.

The three options put the full scope back in front of the client at the real price, next to what the budget buys. Whichever they pick, the rate held.

Copy and paste: the revised scope's inclusions and exclusions

Included: [each deliverable, with its length]. [One] round of revisions per deliverable. A round is one consolidated set of changes.

Not included: [the third social cut / the behind-the-scenes piece / raw footage delivery]. Available as a separate quote.

Variations: a new location, new interviewees, a change of brief after script approval, or a further round of changes are quoted and agreed before the work starts.

Copy and paste: the one line for the quiet month

The quiet month is the worst time to discount.

Pin that where you quote from. Cash-flow panic is the moment every rule in this guide collapses, and the quiet month is when you can least afford to teach a client you're negotiable.

A worked example

Here's the move on one member's job, anonymised, with the numbers rounded.

A brand video. The brief said a budget of \$5,000 plus GST, so he quoted \$5,000 on the dot: planning, filming, the brand film and three 30-second social edits. Then the client clarified. They'd meant \$5,000 including GST. The GST came out of the five thousand before he saw it, so the fee was lower than it looked, and all of it came out of a margin that was already thin for the quality he wanted to deliver.

	The discount route	The scope route (what he did)
Price to the client	\$5,000 including GST	\$5,000 including GST
Planning and filming	As quoted	As quoted
Social edits	Three	Fewer
Effective rate	Lower	Unchanged
What the client learnt	The first number had room in it	The price is real, the scope is the variable

He said it plainly: "To meet that budget we'd reduce the scope. Planning and filming stay the same to protect the quality you're after. I'd deliver fewer social edits rather than the three we discussed." Budget met, rate per hour intact, quality protected, and a client with no reason to open low next time.

Now the other version. A different owner, a quiet month, a competitor undercutting him. He was cutting a \$7,000 job to \$4,700, nearly a third off. Whatever happened to that job, the discount told the client as clearly as it can be said that \$7,000 had been padding.

What if the client says they'll go elsewhere?

Sometimes they will, and a job won on a discount is a client trained to push. You'd rather lose a price-shopper than win a relationship that underpays you for years.

And reducing scope often keeps the job anyway. Treat the client as someone with a number they can sign off who needs the work to fit it, not someone trying to beat you down, and the three options give them a way to do that. If the only version

they'll accept is the full scope at the lower price, that's a client showing you what every future job with them looks like. Believe them.

The mistakes that undo it

The move fails in five predictable ways, and every one of them ends with the rate moving.

- **Cutting the price and keeping the scope.** Same work, less money, and the client now knows the number was soft. This is the whole leak in one line.
- **Cutting the planning or the filming instead of the deliverables.** The budget is met and the film is worse, and the client judges the worse film as your standard. Protect the parts that carry the quality.
- **Framing the reduction as a favour.** "I can probably do something" and "let me see what I can do" both say the price had room in it. The script is a trade: this budget buys this much.
- **Letting the quiet month set the price.** The \$7,000 job that became \$4,700. A rate set in panic is the rate that client expects for good.
- **Discounting to be liked.** The owner who discounts to be liked ends up resenting the job he fought to win. The one who moves the scope keeps both the margin and the goodwill.

The rule of thumb for a lower budget

Scope flexes, the rate doesn't. The rate you built from your overheads and your real sellable days is a floor, not an opening position. When the budget is lower than the quote, the deliverables, rounds and timing come down until the work fits the money, and the rate never moves. If you don't yet know your floor, build it first in [How to price a video project](#).

Hold yourself accountable

Which of these have you taken on or put in place recently?

- You know your floor, so you know what a discount actually costs you per day.
- Your scope script is written down, in your words, before the next tight budget arrives.
- The last time a client said "that's more than we've got", what moved was scope, not price.
- Your revised quotes list what's in, what's out, and what triggers a variation.

Your one move this week

What's the one thing you can commit to implementing this week? If you're not sure, start here.

Write your scope-reduction sentence now, before you need it, so the next tight budget gets the calm version instead of the panicked discount. Take the script above, swap in the deliverables you actually sell, and read it out loud once at natural speed. Then put it where you quote from.

One thing executed every week creates 50 strategic moves a year.

Questions like these come up regularly on our weekly Elite Boardroom calls. If you'd like someone to hold you to account each week, and to learn from a group of peers who run video businesses too, [the Boardroom is for you](#).

Related tools and guides. [How to price a video project](#) (the floor), [What to say when they ask "roughly how much?"](#) (the range conversation), [Anatomy of a Profitable Quote](#), [The three revision emails](#), [Charging for the invisible work](#), [How to push back on a client without losing them](#).



The field guides show you how the system works. The Boardroom is where I look at your business with you, give you perspective and judgement on what to do next, and hold you to it every week.

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